

Chapter 1

Polarity sensitivity and fragments in Irish

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In Irish, negative polarity items may serve, isolated, as fragment answers, something which seems initially to be both theoretically and typologically anomalous. This chapter explores some theoretical consequences of this observation. It begins by arguing that the apparent anomaly is real; that is, that the relevant fragments are in fact negative polarity items. It then argues that the anomaly can be resolved. The possibility of fragment negative polarity items is parasitic on an independent property of the language, namely that it possesses a movement operation (so-called Narrative Fronting) by which a narrow scope indefinite may be raised to a position to the left of the verb in a finite negative clause. It is argued that this option feeds a sluicing-like process of clausal ellipsis, and that this operation may strand licensed negative polarity items. In the context of ‘move and delete’ analyses of fragments, as developed especially by Merchant 2004, the apparently anomalous possibility is routine. A by-product of the discussion is a more complete mapping of the landscape of polarity sensitive items in Irish than has so far been provided.

1 Background and goals

The English question-answer pair in (1) is ill-formed:

- (1) A: What did the priest say? B: *Anything.

Its apparent Irish counterpart in (2), however, is routine and well-formed:

- (2) A: Cad a dúirt an sagart? B: Aon rud.
what c say.PAST the priest any thing
A: ‘What did the priest say?’ B: ‘Anything’.

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To express what Irish expresses by way of (2), English must use (3), exploiting the presence in its lexicon of the inherently negative expression *nothing*, used here as a fragment answer:

- (3) A: What did the priest say? B: Nothing.

This chapter is concerned with the theoretical issues raised by the contrasts in (2–3). Those issues are important in part because the Irish possibility shown in (2) seems to represent a theoretical and typological anomaly. Negative polarity items are not supposed to be able to function, in isolation, as fragment answers.¹

The first goal of this chapter is to establish that this interesting and unexpected possibility does in fact exist; the answer in (2) really does consist solely (in its overt form) of a negative polarity item. Its second goal is to develop a way of understanding that possibility which resolves the apparent anomaly. Its third goal is to consider some larger implications which flow from that account for the general theory of subsentential fragments and for the theory of ellipsis.

A by-product of the discussion will be a more complete map of the landscape of polarity sensitive items in Irish than has so far been available. Most discussions of polarity sensitivity currently available deal with languages that have among their lexical resources expressions which are inherently negative, such as English *nobody*, *nothing* or *never*. I will argue here, though, that Acquaviva (1996) was right to claim that Irish has no such expressions. We are thus presented with an opportunity to explore what patterns emerge in their absence.

Two sources of data form the basis for that exploration here: work with six native speaker consultants over a period of several years, along with a collection of 1800 naturally occurring examples of polarity sensitive items of various kinds and in various contexts of use.²

Some terminological preliminaries to begin with. I will use the term ‘polarity sensitive expression’ (PSE) for such elements as *aon rud* in 2 or *never* in English. These are expressions whose interpretation and well-formedness depend on the polarity of the larger environment in which they find themselves. The set of PSEs is the superset which includes as subsets both negative polarity items (NPIs) and ‘inherently negative expressions’ (INEs), which is the term I will use here for the elements called variously ‘*n*-words’ or ‘negative indefinites’ or ‘negative

¹The star on English (1) is well-deserved, but there are conditions under which NPIs may appear as fragment answers in English. This issue is taken up in Section 4.4 below.

²Examples from this corpus are indicated by a tag consisting of an abbreviation of the title (in the case of published texts) followed by a number indicating the page from which the example was extracted. The abbreviations used in these tags are explained in Appendix Two.

quantifiers’ in other discussions (English *nothing* or French *personne*). In some languages and varieties, such expressions may stand alone to express sentential negation; in others, they must or may enter into negative concord dependencies to serve that function.

2 The landscape of polarity sensitivity in Irish

In presenting the contrast between Irish (2) and English (1), I glossed the Irish *aon rud* as English ‘any thing’. If I had instead chosen to use ‘no thing’ as the gloss, I could have created the impression that there was no anomaly to be concerned about, since many languages allow inherently negative expressions to function as fragment answers. The glossing decision, then, mirrors an important theoretical issue in this case. Consider the pair of Irish examples in (4)³:

- (4) a. Ní-or iarr duine ar bith orm é.
 C.NEG-PAST ask.PAST person any on.me it
 ‘Nobody asked me for it.’
 b. *D’ iarr duine ar bith orm é.
 PAST ask.PAST person any on.me it

Since (4b) is impossible, we know that *duine ar bith* cannot express negation (and is, in fact, ill-formed) when not within an appropriate licensing environment. In (4a) it appears in just such an environment – that determined by the clause-initial sentential negation. It is therefore well-formed and the meaning it expresses is that of the English translation. *Duine ar bith* in (4a) must then be either a negative polarity item or an INE in a concord dependency with the clause-initial negation (e.g., Labov 1972; Laka 1990; Haegeman & Zanuttini 1991; Ladusaw 1992; Zanuttini 1997; Penka & Zeijlstra 2010; Zeijlstra (2004; 2008; 2016); Giannakidou & Zeijlstra 2017; Deal 2022). But, given the possibility of (2), to maintain consistency with the received wisdom concerning fragment answers, we must assume that *aon rud* (and many similar expressions we will encounter

³The glossing conventions used are, for the most part, familiar and transparent but a few notes are in order. Because the inflected prepositions are not a matter of concern here, they are glossed for readability using English pronouns. So Irish *liom* is glossed as ‘with.me’. The ‘direct relative’ complementizer is glossed as c.wh and the marker of polar interrogatives as c.q. All other complementizers, including the conditional, are simply glossed as c. Past and conditional forms of the complementizers are segmentalized, so that, for instance, *gur* is spelled *gu-r* and glossed as C-PAST. ‘Autonomous’ forms of verbs are glossed as IMPERS and imperative forms as IMPV. The particle *a*, which precedes verbal nouns, is glossed as VCE (suggesting ‘voice’) and verbal nouns themselves are glossed with .vn. The progressive particle *ag* is glossed as PROG.

shortly) are not NPIs but are rather INEs. However, Acquaviva (1996) has argued that Irish (like Māori⁴) possesses no INEs. If he is right, it follows *a fortiori* that Irish cannot be a negative concord language. And it follows in turn that *duine ar bith* in (4) and *aon rud* in the fragment answer of (2) must be NPIs and that the apparent conflict with typological and theoretical expectation is real.

It is important, then, to determine whether the pattern in (4) reflects a negative concord system or an NPI-centered system, and the first business of the present chapter will be to address that question. Making such a distinction, though, is not as straightforward as it once seemed to be; the empirical and theoretical landscapes seem more intricate than they once did (see Laka 1993 and, especially, Herburger 2001). I will argue, though, that Acquaviva was correct about the absence of INEs in Irish, that all of its polarity sensitive expressions are in fact NPIs, and that the theoretical questions raised by (2) are therefore real.

Two convictions drive the discussion. The first is that the distribution of NPIs is determined by fundamentally semantic and pragmatic relations (Fauconnier (1975; 1979); Ladusaw 1979; Heim 1984; Kadmon & Landman 1993; Krifka 1995; Zwarts 1996; van der Wouden (1994; 1997); Giannakidou 1998; Lahiri 1998; von Stechow 1999; Hoeksema 2000; Gajewski (2005; 2011); Guerzoni & Sharvit 2007; Homer 2011: Chap. 2; Chierchia 2013; Crnič 2014; Gajewski & Hsieh 2014; Barker 2018; Crnič 2019; Homer 2021; Jeong & Roelefsen 2023). The second is that INEs, though they may well be strong NPIs in their semantics, are licensed in negative concord dependencies by featural interactions in the syntax, subject to characteristically syntactic requirements of locality and relative prominence. This is why analyses in terms of the operation AGREE have been so influential and seemed so persuasive in recent years (see Zeijlstra 2008 and recent exchanges among Zeijlstra 2012, Preminger & Polinsky 2015, Bjorkman & Zeijlstra 2019 and Deal 2022).

2.1 The inventory of polarity sensitive expressions

I begin by trying to establish a more complete inventory of polarity sensitive expressions in Irish than has so far been attempted. The element *tada*, illustrated in (5), is one such.

- (5) a. Ní-or ith mé tada ar maidin.
 C.NEG-PAST eat.PAST I anything/nothing on morning
 ‘I didn’t eat anything this morning.’ ‘I ate nothing this morning.’

⁴See Bauer 1997: p. 298–289, §19.5: ‘Negative quantifiers do not exist in Maori. Sentence negation or other lexical means are used.’ Mandarin, Korean and Bengali are also reported to lack such expressions (see Zeijlstra 2008: 15).

- b. *D' ith mé tada ar maidin.
 PAST eat.PAST I anything/nothing on morning

Tada (and its dialectal variants *dada* and *dadaidh*) is one member of a large class of elements united by a shared distribution and a shared interpretive profile. Like *tada*, they express existential quantification in the scope of sentential negation and are ill-formed when not so licensed. The illustrative examples below have the candidate elements in the scope of sentential negation, but readers should assume that the corresponding example without negation is ungrammatical. This is true for almost every case considered. Elements for which it is not (entirely) true will be discussed in Section 2.3 below. The larger class of environments in which PSEs appear (which do not all involve the explicit appearance of negation) will be considered in Section 2.2.

The class of PSEs of this type includes nominals, along with some adverbs of temporal perspective. The nominal group in turn includes two subtypes: a class of monomorphemic lexical items that stand alone (as in 5) and more complex nominal expressions that include one of a set of functional elements that define the containing expression as a PSE. One element of the latter type is the prepositional phrase *ar bith* (diachronically or literally ‘in the world’ or ‘on earth’), which we have already encountered in (4a), and which is exemplified further in (6). This is a post-nominal modifier which attaches to indefinites in certain environments and converts its host into a PSE. Note that since negation is high in Irish (marked on *c* in finite clauses), elements in subject position will always be in the semantic scope and in the syntactic domain of negation when it is present (Acquaviva 1996; Duffield 1995; McCloskey 1996; McCloskey 2001; McCloskey 2017).⁵

- (6) a. Ní-or thóg bean ar bith de na mná seo riamh
 C.NEG-PAST take.PAST woman any of the women DEMON ever
 an fiabhras.
 the fever
 ‘None of these women ever contracted fever.’ GOG 132

⁵ An anonymous reviewer raises the interesting question of whether or not the alternative word in Irish for the numeral ‘one’ (*amháin*) may also determine a PSE. The answer is that it does not. The two elements differ in a number of ways from one another: *aon* is pre-nominal, *amháin* is post-nominal. *Amháin* has a use as a focus particle meaning ‘only’, while *aon* does not. The question of why and how the two elements differ in their ability to determine a PSE clearly deserves a fuller investigation than is possible here and almost certainly has implications for the fundamental question of what makes a PSE. I am grateful to the reviewer for raising this important issue, even if these remarks in response must remain unsatisfying.

- b. Níl taibhsí ar bith ann agus ní raibh ariamh.
 is.not ghosts any in.it and C.NEG.FIN be.PAST (n)ever
 ‘There are no ghosts and there never were.’ COC 156

The numeral *aon* ‘one’, in addition, can be used to determine polarity sensitive nominals and in this use (and only in this use) it may compose with mass nouns (see 7b-c) and, in some dialects at least, with plural count nouns (see 7d).

- (7) a. Ní-or dúradh aon chuid de seo riamh go hoscailte.
 C.NEG-PAST say.PAST.IMPERS one part of this (n)ever openly
 ‘No part of this was ever said openly.’ PNG 187
- b. Ní-or thugais aon ghrá ceart riamh dom.
 C.NEG-PAST give.PAST.S2 one love proper (n)ever to.me
 ‘You never gave me any proper love.’ ANNF 59
- c. Ní raibh aon eolas eile ar a mhalairt.
 C.NEG.FIN be.PAST one knowledge other on its alternative
 ‘Nobody knew any different.’ LAN 26
- d. Ní raibh aon bháid ar an Oileán ag na chéad daoine.
 C.NEG.FIN be.PAST one boat.PL on the Island at the first people
 ‘The first people on the Island hadn’t any boats.’ LAN 27

Éinne (in western and southern varieties) is a fusion of *aon* with the noun *duine* ‘person’:

- (8) Ní-or labhair éinne ariamh liom.
 C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST anyone (n)ever with.me
 ‘Nobody ever spoke to me.’

Among the elements which seem to lack any internal structure are *tada/dada*, *faic*, and *a dhath*, all of which correspond to English ‘anything’ or ‘nothing’.⁶

- (9) a. Ní dúrt faic.
 C.NEG.FIN say.PAST.S1 anything
 ‘I didn’t say anything.’ AGFC 181

⁶Such elements, while themselves monomorphemic, can be “strengthened” by addition of *ar bith* or minimizers of the type to be considered in the subsection which follows:

- (i) Ní-or ghá dóibh tada ar bith beo eile a dhéanamh aríst go deo.
 C.NEG-PAST need to.them nothing any alive other do.NFIN again ever
 ‘They never had to do a single solitary thing ever again.’ AFAP 33

- b. Ní léann siad tada.
C.NEG.FIN read.PRES they anything
'They don't read anything.' ACED 267
- c. Ní ba léir dó a dhath ariamh.
C.NEG.FIN COP.PAST clear to.him anything (n)ever
'Nothing was ever clear to him.' GFH 102

In Munster dialects, the element *puinn* is also available. It can appear pre-nominally as in (10a), or alone, as in (10b), with the meaning 'at all' or 'much':

- (10) a. Ní-or fhág puinn bád riamh an t-oileán seo.
C.NEG-PAST leave.PAST any boat ever the island DEMON
'No boat ever left this island.' CFC 129
- b. Ní fhaca puinn ina dhiaidh sin é.
C.NEG.FIN see.PAST.S1 any after that him
'I didn't see him much at all after that.' LGL 421

The polarity sensitive adverbs are adverbs of temporal perspective like (a)*riamh* 'ever, still', *choíche*, *go brách*, *go deo* 'ever, forever'. The first (*riamh*) is seen in (6a, 6b, 7a, 7b, 9c) and (10a). The others are exemplified in (11).

- (11) a. Cuirimse de gheasa ort gan aon fhear a choíche
put.PRES.S1 of injunctions on.you NEG.NONFIN any man ever
a phósadh.
VCE marry.NFIN
'I put you under an injunction not to ever marry any man.' SRNF 49
- b. Ní-or mhaith leis a bheith go deo ag caint air
C.NEG-PAST good with.him be.NFIN ever PROG talk on.him
féin.
REFL.LOG
'He didn't like to ever be talking about himself.' LGL 109

Within this group there is also an extensive catalog of expressions conventionally taken to denote the lowest possible point on some scale, so-called 'minimizers'. *Smid* 'breath' refers to the tiniest sound audible, *deor* 'drop' to the smallest imaginable quantity of a liquid, *ceo* 'mist' to the most insubstantial thing, while *pioc* 'a pick' refers to the smallest measure imaginable.

- (12) a. Ach ní-or labhair sé smid leofa.
but C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST he breath with.them
'But he didn't breathe a word to them.' SIF 33
- b. Ní-or chaoin sé deoir ariamh ina shaol.
C.NEG-PAST cry.PAST he drop ever in.his life
'He never shed a tear in his life.' GDDR 166
- c. Ach ní-or fhéad sé ceo a dhéanamh.
but C.NEG-PAST can.PAST he mist do.NFIN
'But he couldn't do a thing.' CC 79
- d. Níl pioc fírinne i n-a cheann.
is.not pick truth.GEN in his head
'He is incapable of telling the truth.' BTFS 124

An Irish particularity (apparently) is that many minimizers are conventionalized disjunctions with the disjunction necessarily interpreted within the scope of negation:

- (13) a. Ní-or ghéill sí ionga ná orlach don chiúnas.
C.NEG-PAST yield.PAST she fingernail or inch to.the silence
'She didn't yield an inch to the silence.'
- b. Ní thabharfadh duine ná deoraí freagra air.
C.NEG.FIN give.COND person or exile/stranger answer on.him
'Not a soul would answer him.'
- c. Ní raibh tásc ná tuairisc ar an chainteoir.
C.NEG-PAST be.PAST sign or report on the speaker
'There wasn't a sign or a trace of the speaker.'
- d. Ní-or chorruigheadar lámh ná cos ariamh ar a son.
C.NEG-PAST move.PASTP3 hand or foot ever on-their-behalf
'They didn't ever lift a finger on their behalf.'
- e. Ní-or fhág sé bonn bán ná pingin rua ag a clann
C.NEG-PAST leave.PAST he coin white or penny red at her family
sise.
she
'But he didn't leave a penny to her family.' CTP 4

There are certain other minimizers which should be mentioned as well. The prepositional phrase *dá laghad* 'of the least' acting as a post-nominal modifier may create one such:

- (14) Níl aird dá laghad aici ar an mbeirt.
 is.not attention of.the least at.her on the two.people
 ‘She doesn’t pay the slightest attention to the two of them.’

And in a slightly more colorful turn of phrase, we have *faic na fríde*. *Faic* is the monomorphemic element already discussed in this section, meaning ‘nothing’ or ‘anything’. When modified by the possessor *na fríde* ‘of the mite’ it signifies ‘the slightest/tiniest thing’:

- (15) Níl faic na fríde le déanamh acu.
 is.not to do.VN at.them
 ‘They have nothing whatever to do.’

Finally, some minimizers are based on now opaque metaphors. In the Irish of Conamara, for example, the expression *mac an éin bheo* ‘the son of the living bird’ refers to the smallest possible set of people:

- (16) Ní raibh mac an éin bheo le feiceáil an tráth
 C.NEG.FIN be.PAST son the bird.GEN living.GEN ASP see.VN the time
 sin de mhaidin.
 DEMON of morning
 ‘There wasn’t a single solitary person to be seen at that time of the morning.’

There will be little or nothing in this inventory to surprise those who have closely studied the inventory of negative polarity systems in other languages.

2.2 Beyond negation: The licensing environments

We have so far considered just one environment in which the PSEs described in the previous section may appear: in the scope of sentential negation. But their distribution is, in fact, much broader.⁷

⁷Before extending the investigation to licensing contexts beyond that of negation, we should note that PSEs are also licensed in the scope of the emphatic or ‘demonic’ negation studied by Ó Siadhail (1989: 326–331) and especially by D’Antuono (2023). In this construction a phrase is fronted to a position immediately to the right of the emphatic negators *diabhal* ‘devil’ or *dheamhan* ‘demon’ and the clause out of which the phrase is extracted is headed by the WH-complementizer. PSEs may be fronted (as in i) or appear in a clause-internal position (as in ii):

All of them, for instance, also appear in the scope of semi-negative expressions such as ‘rarely’ or ‘hardly’ – which in Irish are predicates that select clausal complements (nonfinite or finite):

- (17) Is rí-annamh anois éinne acu a theacht abhaile.
COP.PRES very-rare now anyone of.them come.NFIN home
'It's very rare now for any of them to come home.'
CAA 265
- (18) Ar éigean a bheas tada le déanamh agat.
hardly c be.FUT anything PTC do.NFIN at.you
'You'll have hardly anything to do.'
AA 215

The PSEs we are concerned with appear in fact in a broad range of environments, all of them characteristic of those in which NPIs have been shown to appear in other languages. Documenting this pattern and its breadth is important work, but it makes for tedious reading. I have therefore gathered the relevant data in Appendix One. What is shown there is that PSEs in Irish, with their characteristic existential interpretations, are licensed in the following range of environments:

1. In polar questions
2. In WH-questions (when rhetorical or when demanding exhaustive, rather than partial, answers)
3. In conditional clauses (realis and irrealis)
4. In equative clauses
5. In comparative and superlative clauses
6. In phrases and clauses introduced by the degree particle *ró*- ‘too’
7. In certain temporal clauses introduced by *sul* ‘before’ or *nuair* ‘when’

- (i) Dheamhan freagra ar bith a thug sí orm.
demon answer any C.WH give.PAST she on.me
'Not an answer did she give me.' AA 240
- (ii) Diabhal duine a thug aon aird orm.
devil person C.WH give.PAST any attention on.me
'Not a person paid any attention to me.' DGD 79

8. In the complement of adversative (and some implicative) predicates
9. In the restrictive clauses of universal quantification structures

This is a list which is familiar from decades of research on NPIs. Appendix One documents this distribution and also considers some particularities of the Irish patterns, having to do especially with the licensing potential of adversative and negative implicative predicates.

Irish PSEs may in fact appear in an additional environment which, as far as I have been able to tell, has not so far been identified for NPIs in other languages – in clauses introduced by (the equivalent of) *to the extent that*. This is illustrated in (19):

- (19) To the extent that anyone ever believed this ...
 sa mhéid is gu-r chuir mé aithne ar bith air
 in.the extent as C-PAST put.PAST I acquaintance any on.him
 ‘to the extent that I got to know him at all’LSC 130

The licensing potential of such a context presumably arises from the implication of doubt or of disbelief that it conveys concerning the content of the complement clause.

In sum: the distribution of PSEs in Irish and the distribution of NPIs in other well-studied languages are parallel in strikingly complete and exact ways. And although real progress has been made in recent years on the question of what this broad range of environments might have in common in terms of their semantics (for overviews, see Giannakidou 2011, Chierchia 2013, or Homer 2020), the task of identifying any plausible syntactic commonality, one that might provide the basis for an agreement or concord relation, seems very challenging.

2.3 Available readings

It is a well-known, if not well-understood, property of NPI systems that a subset of the NPIs of a language may appear outside the licensing environments just listed, but with quasi-universal (or perhaps generic) rather than existential force. These are the so-called “free choice” readings of certain NPIs (Bolinger 1972; Horn 1989: 400 ff; Horn 2000; Chierchia 2013: Chap. 6). Roughly half of the 115 languages in the Haspelmath (1997) sample allow this option for some of their negative polarity items. Irish can be added to that subgroup. The ill-formed (5b) above, for example, is well-formed if the main verb is in conditional mood:

- (20) D' íosfadh sé tada.
 PAST eat.COND he anything
 'He'd eat anything.'

Among the PSEs, all but the minimizers allow such readings. The facilitating environments are the familiar ones – modal contexts (as in 20) or the presence of a restrictive modifier such as a relative clause modifying the PSE ('subtriggering' in the sense of LeGrand 1975). This possibility is exemplified for the nominal PSEs in (21) and in (22). (21) illustrates the modal environment (generic in 21b); those in (22) illustrate the 'subtriggering' effect.

- (21) a. Ceann de na hoícheanta sin go dtarlódh faic
 one of the nights DEMON C happen.COND anything
 'one of those nights when anything could happen' LGL 250
- b. maidir le daoine bochta, tá rud ar bith sách maith dóibh.
 as-for people poor be.PRES thing any enough good for.them
 'As for poor people – anything is good enough for them.' CG 59
- c. Dhéanfainn rud ar bith ach tusa a fháil domh féin.
 do.COND.S1 thing any but you VCE get.VN to.me REFL.LOG
 'I'd do anything to get you for myself.' SSOTC 222
- (22) a. Rud ar bith a tugadh ar iasacht domsa ariamh thug
 thing any C give.PAST.IMPERS on loan to.me ever give.PAST
 mé ar ais é.
 I back it
 'Anything that I was ever lent, I gave it back.' AA 90
- b. Aon áit a chuais, ní raibh aon ní á
 one/any place C go.PAST.S2 C.NEG-PAST be.PAST any thing PROG.PASS
 labhairt ach Gaolainn.
 speak but Irish
 'Any place you went, there wasn't anything being spoken but Irish.' TMGB 39

The temporal adverbials (*a*)*riamh*, *go brách*, *go deo* and *choíche* 'ever' may, in addition, appear outside the licensing environments just discussed and in that context they have universal rather than existential force and translate as English 'always' or 'forever':

- (23) a. Bhí sé ariamh ann.
be.PAST it ever in.it
'It has always existed.' FF 167
- b. An síleann tú go bhfuil tú ag imeacht go brách uainn?
c.Q think.PRES you c be.PRES you PROG leave.VN forever from.us
'Do you think you are leaving us for ever?' ATFS 207
- c. Bhíodh clocha i nGleann Easa riamh agus beidh go deo.
be.PAST.HABIT stones in ever and be.FUT always
'There have always been stones in Gleann Easa and there always will be.' DEAD 96
- d. Beidh cuimhne choíche agam air.
be.FUT memory ever at.me on.it
'I will always remember it.' OMGS 290

The two meanings expressed by these adverbs are at least close to those expressed by NPIs and their "free choice" counterparts. In addition, both interpretations (existential in NPI-licensing contexts, universal otherwise) are available across the class, suggesting that something more systematic than lexical polysemy is at work. It may be, then, that the possibilities seen in (23) reflect a "free choice" option for certain NPIs. These universal readings, however, are not subject to the licensing restrictions observed for the determiner NPIs such as English *any* (LeGrand 1975; Kadmon & Landman 1993; Dayal 1998; Dayal 2013; Giannakidou 2001; Chierchia 2013: Chap. 6), for which modality or genericity seems to be crucial, neither of which is relevant for (23).

It might, alternatively, be more profitable to think about cases such as (23) as being parallel, in relevant respects, to cases such as English *until* and related items in other European languages. Temporal clauses introduced by *until* are strong NPIs when interpreted as punctual:

- (24) a. He didn't finish the paper until July.
b. * He finished the paper until July.

But when modifying atelic predications they are, as seen in (25), durative in their interpretation and are positive polarity items expressing extension over relatively long intervals (Karttunen 1974; Mittwoch 1977; Giannakidou 1992; Declerck 1995; de Swart 1996; and especially Condoravdi 2008):

- (25) We remained in Cambridge until the end of the year.

The connection with our Irish cases is that the non-NPI readings of the temporal adverbs in (23) also appear only in the context of atelic predications.⁸ Needless to say, this discussion is little more than a marker laid down for a future research project.⁹

2.4 Non-local licensing

One of the principal themes of research on negative concord systems has been that of locality. To a first approximation, the concord relation may not cross a finite clause boundary unless it is subjunctive (Haegeman & Zanuttini 1991, Zeijlstra 2008: 43–45, Deal 2022).¹⁰ This is why analyses of the concord relation in terms of agreement or movement, with their associated locality requirements, have been persuasive and influential. The licensing of PSEs in Irish, however, is subject to no such restriction, as shown by examples like those in (26–28), which are commonplace and frequent (304 in our data-set).

- (26) a. Ní-or chualas gu-r mharaigh na tramanna duine
C.NEG-PAST hear.PAST.S1 C.PAST kill.PAST the trams person
ar bith ariamh.
any ever
'I haven't heard that the trams ever killed anyone.' CTP 49
- b. má cheapann sibh go bhfuil mise ag déanamh aon fhocal
if think.PRES you.PL C be.PRES I PROG make.VN any word
bréige
lie.GEN
'if you think that I am telling any lies' MABAT 56
- c. An síleann tú go dtiocfadh le cailín ar bith grá mar sin a
C.Q think.PRES you C could girl any love like that VCE
thabhairt uaithe?
give.VN from.her
'Do you think that any girl could give such love?' ATFS 343

In each of the cases in (26), the licensing element (negation, the complementizer *má* in (26b) or the polar interrogative particle in (26c)) is separated from the PSE it

⁸The same restriction seems to hold for the more or less archaic use of English *ever* when universal in its force (see Israel 1998; Horn 2000: 181–183).

⁹I am grateful to Nicola D'Antuono for discussion of these matters.

¹⁰For complications, exceptions, and for approaches to those issues, see Robinson & Thoms (2021), among others.

licenses by at least one finite CP-boundary. Longer dependencies are also possible, as in (27). In (27a), the licensed PSE is separated from its licensing negation by two finite clause boundaries, one of them the complement to the experiencer noun *súil* ‘hope’; in (27b) the licensing environment is established by the noun *eagla* ‘fear’, which is adversative and licenses PSEs in its complement.

- (27) a. Ní hamhlaidh [_{CP} a tá súil agam [_{CP} go dtiocfaidh
COP.NEG SO C be.PRES hope at.me C come.FUT
éinne]].
anyone
‘It is not the case that I really expect that anyone will come.’ LGL 60
- b. ar eagla [_{CP} go gceapfadh sé [_{CP} go raibh duine ar bith díobh
on fear C think.COND he C be.PAST person any of.them
chomh díthcéillí]]
so foolish
‘for fear that he would think that any of them were so foolish’ ATIM 90

The licensing relation can also span at least some island-boundaries, as seen in (28), a WH-island in (28a)¹¹, and in (28b) a finite CP-argument of the noun *cuma* ‘appearance’. Such structures are strong islands in Irish (McCloskey 1985; McCloskey 2002; Maki & Ó Baoill 2011.)

- (28) a. Cha-r fhoghlaim mé ariamh cén dóigh le rud ar bith a
C.NEG-PAST learn.PAST I ever what way with thing any VCE
tharraingt.
draw.VN
‘I didn’t ever learn how to draw anything.’ APB 12
- b. Ní raibh cuma uirthi go raibh eagla ar bith roimh
C.NEG.FIN be.PAST appearance on.her C be.PAST fear any before
an astar uirthi.
the journey on.her
‘It didn’t look as if she had any fear of the journey.’ NLAB 54

¹¹For (28a) one might wonder whether the PSE is licensed in the interrogative clause itself rather than by the matrix negation. This is not a plausible interpretation, though, given that the WH-interrogative is neither rhetorical nor exhaustive. In addition, the example is ill-formed when the matrix negation is removed.

2.5 Modification by ‘almost’

Finally, all PSEs in Irish strongly resist modification by *almost*, a property which in many languages distinguishes NPIs from inherently negative expressions:

- (29) a. *Ní raibh comhair a bheith duine ar bith i láthair.
C.NEG-PAST be.PAST almost person any present
‘There was almost nobody present.’
b. *Ní dhéanainn freastal ar chomhair a bheith
C.NEG-PAST do.PAST.HABIT.S1 attendance on almost
léacht ar bith.
lecture any
‘I attended almost no lectures.’

2.6 Interim conclusion

The items surveyed in this section (all of the PSEs so far identified in Irish), while being polarity sensitive: (i) are incapable of expressing negation outside an appropriate licensing context, (ii) appear in the range of environments typical of NPIs investigated in other languages, (iii) support quasi-universal readings outside those environments, (iv) can be licensed non-locally, even across certain island boundaries, and (v) are incompatible with modification by *almost*. All of this suggests that Acquaviva (1996) was correct in arguing that Irish possesses a rich and familiar inventory of negative polarity items but has no plausible candidate for the role of inherently negative expression, as far as is known at present. It therefore also lacks the mechanisms of negative concord and our PSEs are negative polarity items.¹² From this point on, then, I will abandon the neutral term PSE and call all of the items discussed here negative polarity items (NPIs).

In light of that conclusion, however, the observations of the section which follows seem unpleasantly anomalous.

¹²Elena Herburger (2001) develops an important analysis of the distribution of polarity sensitive expressions in Spanish, another case in which the distinction between NPIs and INEs seems less than clear. She shows that that complex of data can be accounted for on the assumption that the relevant PSEs in Spanish are systematically ambiguous between being NPIs and items lexically specified as being ‘negative’. Her analysis is remarkably successful, but it cannot be applied to the problems we deal with in the following section. In Spanish, the class of elements Herburger examines can always express negation on their own, so to speak (because they are inherently negative expressions). But that is not possible for the class of Irish elements we are concerned with here, as we have seen with examples like (5b) above. Put differently, the set of contexts in which the ‘*n*-words’ of Spanish may appear is the union of the distributions of NPIs and what I have called here INEs, a distribution much broader than that of the Irish PSEs we are concerned with.

3 The anomaly

Each of the polarity sensitive elements identified in the previous section may appear in apparent isolation as a subsentential fragment, often in answer to a WH-question (as in 30 or 2 above) or to a polar question (as in 31).^{13,14}

(30) NPIs AS FRAGMENT ANSWERS TO WH-QUESTIONS:

- a. “Céard a tá uait?” “Tada, a Mháistir.”
 what c.WH be.PRES from.you anything, VOC-PTC Master
 “What do you want?” “Nothing, sir.” LL 254
- b. “Agus caidé a ghní tú leis na réaltógaí?” “Rud ar bith.”
 and what c.WH do you with the stars thing any
 “And what do you do with the stars?” “Nothing.” APB 47
- c. “Cén chúis a gcuirfeá an cheist sin orm?” “Ó, cúis
 what reason c put.COND.S2 the question DEMON on.me oh reason
 ar bith.”
 any
 “Why would you ask me that question?” “Oh, no reason.” LOFRS 241
- d. ach cé labhrann liom í? Éinne ach do leithéidse.
 but who speak.PRES with.me it anyone but your like
 ‘But who speaks it to me? Nobody except the likes of you.’ TMGB 252

(31) NPIs AS FRAGMENT ANSWERS TO POLAR QUESTIONS:

- a. “An ndéanfaidh aon duine m’ áit-sa duit?” “Go deo.”
 c.Q make.FUT any person my place for.you ever
 “Will anyone ever take my place for you?” “Never.” ATFS 488
- b. “An bhfaigheadh na scéalaithe aon díolaíocht?” “Aon rud
 c.Q get.PAST.HABIT the storytellers any payment any thing
 in aon chor.”
 at.all
 “Would the storytellers get any payment?” “Nothing at all.” AL 88
- c. “Agus ní raibh eagla ort roimhe?” “Eagla ar bith.”
 and c.NEG.FIN be.PAST fear on.you before.him fear any
 “And you weren’t afraid of him?” “Not at all.” D 18

¹³Gary Thoms reports that similar facts hold for Scottish Gaelic.

¹⁴Example (30b) is from a translation of *Le Petit Prince* by Antoine de Sainte-Exupéry. The French original has: *Et que fais-tu de ces étoiles? Rien. Je les possède.*

It is perhaps worth emphasizing that the answers in (30) and (31) are in no way strained. They require no particular contextualization, nor do they demand any special accommodation. They are routine, and as far as I am aware, there is no alternative way to express what they express (fully articulated clauses aside).

There are additional contexts in which such NPI fragments appear, contexts that do not (in an obvious way at least) involve question-answer pairings. We will return to those cases and their implications, but the dilemma is already clear. If the arguments developed so far in this chapter are to be relied upon, bare NPIs may function as fragment answers in Irish. But there is very strong evidence from a range of languages already studied that NPIs cannot serve as fragment answers. In fact, this has come to be recognized as one of the most reliable diagnostics for distinguishing between NPIs and inherently negative expressions. As Penka & Zeijlstra (2010: 778) put it:

The ability to contribute negation in fragmentary answers can, thus, be regarded as a defining property of negative indefinites, distinguishing them from NPIs (cf. Bernini and Ramat 1996 and Haspelmath 1997).

We might, in the face of this dilemma, reject the arguments of the first half of this chapter and conclude that all Irish polarity sensitive expressions are actually negative indefinites. My own assessment (unsurprisingly) is that this would not be a wise move and in the remainder of the chapter, I propose an analysis which preserves those earlier results, while also preserving the basic integrity of the generalization articulated by Penka and Zeijlstra. The resolution proposed is well-supported by evidence internal to Irish, and it also has interesting theoretical implications. The questions which need to be addressed in such a resolution are these:

- How can the fragments in (30–31) be well-formed outside the licensing context that they otherwise require?
- How can such examples have the interpretations that they do in the absence of that crucial licensing environment?
- Why are the mechanisms, whatever they may be, that underlie the possibility in (30–31) unavailable in the other languages so far examined?

The answer to all of these questions, I believe, is that Irish has a movement rule whose very particular properties are crucial in permitting the possibilities on display in (30–31).

4 The resolution

4.1 Narrative fronting

Ó Siadhail (1989: §9.2.2) and McCloskey (1996) discuss a process, named by Ó Siadhail *Narrative Fronting*, by way of which a phrase is moved leftward in a finite clause to a position immediately to the left of the negative complementizer and, therefore, also to the left of the inflected verb. The process is productive and of high frequency.¹⁵

A variety of phrase-types may be fronted, but the most frequently attested pattern is one in which the moved phrase is an indefinite nominal within the scope of the triggering negation. The fronted phrase is nominal in (32), adverbial or prepositional in (33).

(32) NARRATIVE FRONTING IN NEGATIVE CLAUSES:

- a. Duine níba réasúnaí ní raibh ann.
 person more reasonable.COMPR NEG was in.it
 ‘A more reasonable person was there none.’ FF 107
- b. Mo bhéal ní-or oscail mé ar feadh chúig lá.
 my mouth C.NEG-PAST open.PAST I during five day
 ‘I didn’t as much as open my mouth for five days.’ TUAIR 26-04-21
- c. Leabhar gramadaí ní raibh ariamh agam.
 book grammar.GEN C.NEG-PAST be.PAST ever at.me
 ‘I never had a grammar-book.’ ABHM 41

- (33) a. Ach díreach ní-or bhreathnaigh sí air
 but straight C.NEG-PAST look.PAST she on.him
 ‘But straight she didn’t look at him.’ c 24

¹⁵There is a similar but much less productive process that applies in clauses headed by the complementizer *go* and in which the inflected verb is in subjunctive mood (a form now archaic for almost all speakers). Such clauses express curses (as in ia) or blessings (as in ib):

- (i) a. Na seacht ndiabhal déag go dtuga – leo sibh!
 the seven devil ten c take.SUBJ with.them you.PL
 ‘May the seventeen devils take you!’ CNF 51
- b. Ádh agus sonas go raibh – ort.
 luck and happiness c be.SUBJ on.you
 ‘May you have good fortune and happiness.’ SK 104

Though superficially similar, it is not clear that the two processes have a common syntax. We will be concerned here only with the very productive negative case.

- b. isteach san fháinne ní thiocfaidh sí
 into in.the ring C.NEG.FIN come.FUT she
 ‘Into the ring she will not come.’ SGC 112
- c. Go deo ná go bráthach ní scarfamaoid ón a chéile
 ever or ever C.NEG.FIN separate.FUT.P1 from each-other
 arís.
 again
 ‘Never again will we separate from one another.’ IAE 331

Narrative Fronting is optional and the examples of (32) and (33) are equivalent in their truth-conditions to the corresponding examples in which it has not applied. (32) and (33), though, are felt to be “emphatic” in a way that their counterparts without fronting are not. The general pattern, then, can be schematized as in (34):

(34) NARRATIVE FRONTING:

- a. [XP_j C V ... - j ...]
 [NEG] [FIN]
- b. where XP can be any constituent type but is frequently an indefinite nominal
- c. and the interpretive effect is to express “emphatic” negation.

Narrative Fronting is relevant for us because all of the weak NPIs and all of the minimizers surveyed earlier appear freely and frequently in the XP-position of (34a). The examples in (35) illustrate this fact for the weak NPIs; those in (36) for the minimizers.

(35) WEAK NPIS IN NARRATIVE FRONTING:

- a. Cearta ar bith ní raibh – ag gnáthdhaoine.
 rights any C.NEG.FIN be.PAST at ordinary.people
 ‘Ordinary people had no rights.’ ABHM 53
- b. Aon mhoill ní-or dhein Cromail. –
 any delay C.NEG-PAST make.PAST Cromwell
 ‘Cromwell made no delay.’/ ‘No delay did Cromwell make.’ OOGC 199
- c. Ach tada ní raibh sé in ann – a chloisteáil.
 but anything C.NEG.FIN be.PAST he able VCE hear.VN
 ‘But nothing was he able to hear.’ sjsj 55

- d. Go deo arís ní dhéanfadh fear amadán – dom
 ever again C.NEG.FIN make.COND man fool of.me
 ‘Never again would a man make a fool of me.’ LGL 158
- e. Éinne de na comharsain ní cheannódh é.
 anyone of the neighbors C.NEG.FIN buy.COND it
 ‘None of the neighbors would buy it.’ BM 197

(36) MINIMIZERS IN NARRATIVE FRONTING:

- a. Faic na fríde ní bhfuair mé – mar fhreagra.
 the-tiniest-thing C.NEG.FIN get.PAST I as answer
 ‘I didn’t get the tiniest thing as an answer.’ PAA 24
- b. Smid ní -l – ann faoi Tone.
 breath C.NEG.FIN be.PRES in.it about
 ‘There’s absolutely nothing in it about Tone.’ TH 121
- c. Píoc eagla ní raibh – ar an tiománaí.
 pick fear C.NEG.FIN be.PAST on the driver
 ‘The driver wasn’t the tiniest bit afraid.’ DR 15
- d. Deoir ní-or chaoín sé. –
 drop C.NEG-PAST weep.PAST he
 ‘He didn’t cry a single tear.’ LL 118
- e. Le mac an éin bheo níor sceith ceachtar
 with son the bird.GEN living C.NEG-PAST expose.PAST either
 againn ár rún.
 of.us our secret
 ‘Neither of us revealed our secret to a single living soul.’ LL 437

It is not just that weak NPIs *may* undergo Narrative Fronting; they clearly have a particular affinity for the environment created in (34), as is shown by the fact that in 43% of the attested examples of Narrative Fronting in our database (196 of 486), the element fronted is an NPI. Among these, minimizers are particularly frequent; they represent 41% (80 of 196) of all the examples in which NPIs are fronted under Narrative Fronting.

There is something, then, about the environment of Narrative Fronting that particularly favors NPIs and there is something about NPIs (and minimizers, in particular) which makes them especially susceptible to fronting in this context. This is one of a number of observations suggesting that the two phenomena are deeply entangled. What is the nature of that entanglement though?

The “emphatic” character of Narrative Fronting seems to have its source, at least in part, in that the structure in (34) expresses “scalar assertions” in the sense of Krifka (1995). They evoke scalar implicatures of a familiar kind in that the use of such a structure evokes alternatives to the proposition actually expressed – alternatives that are ranked on a scale of strength. The relevant notion of “strength” is in turn dependent on information shared among interlocutors, but also on the relative informational strength of those alternatives as measured by asymmetric entailment relations. Such ranked alternatives, implicitly evoked, have been central to theoretical work in pragmatics and semantics for many years. In that light, consider the examples of (37):

- (37) a. Acht sagart amháin ní tháinig de chóir fhéasta an Rí.
 but priest one C.NEG.FIN come.PAST near feast the king
 ‘But not a single priest came near the king’s feast.’ UMI 13
- b. Míle fear ní bhainfeadh feacadh aisti as a
 thousand men C.NEG.FIN take.COND movement out.of.it from its
 háit.
 place
 ‘A thousand men couldn’t budge it from its place.’ (a rock) ATT 34

In (37a) the alternatives evoked have to do with the number of priests who had attended the king’s feast – a set of propositions of the form: ‘*n* priests did not attend the king’s feast’ ordered by the value of *n*. The asserted proposition is that the lowest number possible (namely none at all) attended. That is also the strongest proposition among the evoked alternatives because it entails all of the others (i.e., if it is not the case that one priest attended, then it is not the case that two attended, or that three attended, or four or ...). The proposition expressed is therefore the logically strongest and the most informationally specific of the alternative-set. In (37b), the alternative propositions evoked are of the form: ‘*n* men could not move that rock’, and those propositions are ranked by the value of *n* from one thousand down as far as one. The strongest proposition on that scale (in the sense of entailing all of the others and of being, again, informationally more specific) is the one asserted to be true (i.e., if it is impossible for one thousand men to dislodge the rock, it is impossible for 900 to do so and also 800 and so on downwards). The meaning ultimately conveyed, then, is that the rock is likely impossible to dislodge. The proposition actually expressed in both cases is presented as being at the extreme high-point of a scale of salient alternatives. This is the standard logic of scalar implicatures. It seems reasonable, then, to assume

that Narrative Fronting is a syntactic operation which attracts to the XP-position of (34) constituents that evoke alternatives. (38) revises (34) accordingly:

(38) NARRATIVE FRONTING:

- a. [XP_j C V ... - j ...]
 [NEG] [FIN]
- b. where XP is alternative-evoking.

If the phrase fronted in (38) must be alternative-evoking, an additional property of Narrative Fronting falls into place. That phrase is modified very frequently by the focus particle *féin*, a phrase-final focus marker whose meaning is close to that of English ‘even’:

- (39) Bhí an madra féin fachtha mífhoighneach.
 be.PAST the dog *féin* gotten impatient
 ‘Even the dog had become impatient.’ GSA 19

The particle *féin* appears very frequently as a modifier of the phrase fronted under Narrative Fronting:

- (40) a. An toirneach féin ní dhúiseodh Johnny.
 the thunder *féin* C.NEG.FIN waken.COND
 ‘Even thunder wouldn’t waken Johnny.’ C 17
- b. An fhuiseog féin ní raibh ina suí.
 the lark *féin* C.NEG.FIN be.PAST awake
 ‘Even the lark wasn’t awake.’ AN 43
- c. Feoirling féin ní thabharfadh sé dhó.
 farthing *féin* C.NEG.FIN give.COND he to.him
 ‘Even a farthing he wouldn’t give him.’ ATIM 123

This is an expected possibility given (38) because the effect of suffixing *féin* to some phrase XP is exactly to turn XP into an alternative-evoking expression. In the case of (40b), for instance, the alternative propositions evoked have to do with what creatures were up and about that morning. Given conventional ideas about bird life-styles, the lark will always be the earliest creature awake and the proposition that the lark was not awake therefore entails all of the alternative propositions evoked (i.e., the fox was not awake, the hare was not awake, the curlew was not awake ...). What is ultimately conveyed, then, is that no creature stirred and that was because it was really unusually early in the morning.

Such assertions, then, convey that the proposition actually expressed is at the upper limit of some scale of imaginable alternatives and is therefore outside the range of conventional norms and expectations, thereby evoking in hearers a sense of surprise or unexpectedness. This seems to be the principal source of the intuitively “emphatic” character of Narrative Fronting examples; they are scalar assertions in Krifka’s (1995) sense.

Negation plays a central role in these deductions. Its effect is to reverse the direction of entailment among the alternatives and therefore to reverse the ranking of those propositions on the scale of strength. Returning to example (37a), for instance: the proposition *One priest attended the king’s feast* leaves open the possibility that two priests, or three, or four ... attended the feast, but it entails neither those propositions nor their negations. The presence of negation changes that calculation and rules out possibilities that would be allowed in its absence; it therefore ‘converts’ what would be in its absence a logically weak and low-ranked proposition into a logically strong and high-ranked proposition.

This must be why the NPIs which are our central concern are so susceptible to Narrative Fronting.

If there were a class of expressions lexically specified to be alternative-evoking, we would now expect those expressions to appear naturally and frequently in the XP-position of (38). But that is exactly the claim that is at the heart of one of the most important strands of current research on the nature and licensing of NPIs – from the domain-widening of Kadmon & Landman (1993) to the explicit appeal to scalar implicatures in the work of Krifka (1995), Lee & Horn (1994), Israel (1998), Lahiri (1998), Horn (2000), Condoravdi (2008), Chierchia (2013) and Jeong & Roelefsen (2023). The central commitment in this line of work is that the limited distribution of NPIs (that is, that they may appear only in downward-entailing environments) is to be attributed to the fact that they are required in their lexical semantics to be alternative-evoking and further that they are, or at least that many of them are, lexically specified as representing minimal elements on the quantity-scale implicitly defined by those alternatives. But by the logic we just reviewed those “minimal” elements will be strengthened exactly when they appear within the scope of negation. Different theoreticians have different ways of working this reasoning into a formal theory of NPI-licensing, but the common thread, since Krifka (1995), has been that unless such items appear within the scope of negation (or an element with similar logical properties) they run afoul of a version of Grice’s (1975) Quantity Maxim (namely, “be as informative as possible”) built into the compositional mechanisms.

But negation is, of course, also the syntactic driver of Narrative Fronting. Weak NPIs and minimizers will be ideal candidates for the role of XP in (38), then, be-

cause they are in their lexical definition alternative-evoking and minimal. In their interaction with negation, then, they will very naturally generate the logically strong propositions that are the hallmark of the construction.

Given this perspective, we understand why NPIs in Irish appear so frequently in the fronted position of Narrative Fronting structures. The two phenomena are “entangled”, as I put it above, because they exploit the same logical mechanism in evoking scalar implicatures – namely, the strengthening effect of downward entailing contexts. The difference between the two is that Narrative Fronting is syntacticized and so limited to a single downward-entailing environment (the domain of sentential negation), while weak NPIs and minimizers can exploit that logic in any environment that has the appropriate semantics (those described in Section 2.2). The descriptions given earlier now reduce to (41).

(41) NARRATIVE FRONTING:

The finite negation head may include a probe that attracts XPs that are alternative-evoking.

The description in (41), unlike our earlier formulations, makes no mention of the “emphatic” character of Narrative Fronting. That aspect of the construction, as we have seen, emerges organically from the interaction between the semantics of the negative head and the alternatives evoked by the attracted constituent.

A property of this account that is neither obviously correct nor obviously incorrect is that the fronting itself plays no role in establishing the “emphatic” character of Narrative Fronting. On this account, that aspect of the construction emerges from a semantic-pragmatic interaction between the attracting negation and the alternatives evoked by the fronted element; an interaction that would take place even when the alternative-evoking phrase remains in its base position. The pairs of examples in (42) and (43) should then be equally “emphatic”:

- (42) a. Ach ní-or labhair sé smid leofa.
 but C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST he breath with.them
 ‘But he didn’t breathe a word to them.’ SIF 33
- b. Smid níor labhair sé – leofa.
- (43) a. Aon mhoill ní-or dhein Cromaill. –
 any delay C.NEG-PAST make.PAST Cromwell
 ‘No delay did Cromwell make.’ OOGC 199
- b. Níor dhein Cromaill aon mhoill.

Assessing whether or not this prediction is correct is a matter of such subtlety and vagueness that it will be next to impossible to investigate responsibly, I suspect. For what it may be worth (not much), my impression is that it is not obviously incorrect.¹⁶

4.2 Narrative fronting and scope

There is a final property of Narrative Fronting that we need to attend to, one that is implicit in the preceding discussion but which should be made explicit.

It was observed in McCloskey (1996: 76–86) that Narrative Fronting does not expand the scope of the raised item, at least with respect to negation. In (44), for instance, the temporal indefinite *uair amháin* remains within the scope of negation despite apparently preceding it:

- (44) *uair amháin* *fiú*, *ní-or* *cheistigh* *sé conas a bhí* *an*
time one even C.NEG-PAST question.PAST he how c be.PAST the
t-ullmhúchán faoi bhráid Mheiriceá ag *dul*.
preparation for America PROG go.VN
‘Not even once did he ask how the preparation for America was going.’
PI 67

(37a) above is similar, as are the examples in (45):

- (45) a. *Aon mhála amháin ní* *bhfaighidh tú*.
one bag one C.NEG.FIN get.FUT you
‘Not one bag will you get.’
OTA 194

¹⁶Note that to claim that certain expressions are alternative-evoking is not to claim that they are “F-marked” in the sense familiar from work on the distribution of focal accents and contrastive focus (or to claim that Narrative Fronting is movement to a dedicated focal position). Rather I follow Krifka (1995), Jeong & Roelefsen (2023) and others in assuming that expressions in focus evoke alternatives but that that is just one of the contexts in which alternatives play a central role. See Krifka (1995) and Jeong & Roelefsen (2023) for important discussions of the issues that arise here. If we were to assume that the alternative-evoking character of NPIs reflects a kind of inherent focus marking, we are left in a poor position to understand the differences between emphatic and non-emphatic uses of NPIs – the central concern of the discussion in Jeong & Roelefsen (2023). They assume, with Krifka (1995) and others, that all NPIs evoke alternatives, as a matter of lexical specification, but that there is also a distinction between contingently-emphatic and inherently emphatic members of the class. The latter are the minimizers and they are inherently focused; the former may or may not be focused. These commitments are entirely consistent with the discussion here. Chierchia (2013) draws the same distinction in a different way. The minimizers, because they rely on an operator like *even* for the required exhaustification of their alternative-set, are always and strongly emphatic. For run of the mill weak NPIs, like *any*, however, the activation of the relevant alternatives is often undetectable.

- b. duine amháin as ocht nduine dhéag i seomra na nuachtóirí
 person one out.of eight person ten in room the journalists
 ní-or labhair liom air
 C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST with.me on.it
 ‘Not one person out of eighteen in the newsroom spoke to me about it.’
 AAG 027
- c. Duine acu ní-or aithníos.
 person of.them C.NEG-PAST recognize.PAST.S1
 ‘I recognized none of them.’
 BTFS 14

(45c), for example, in its actual context of use, does not convey that there was one person that I did not recognize – a meaning naturally expressible in English by means of *One of them, I didn’t recognize*. Rather, the intended interpretation has the indefinite interpreted within the scope of negation. The examples of (46) show that fronted disjuncts also remain within the scope of the negation which triggers Narrative Fronting.

- (46) a. Do chlann ná do chéile ní fheicfidh tú go deo.
 your family or your spouse C.NEG.FIN see.FUT you ever
 ‘You will never see either your spouse or your family.’
 CDC 230
- b. Agus mionnán ná bainne ní bheadh ... an bhliain sin
 and kid.goat or milk C.NEG.FIN be.COND the year DEMON
 aici.
 at.her
 ‘And she would have neither a goat nor (its) milk that year.’
 CC 16

For detailed discussion see McCloskey (1996).¹⁷

The fact, then, that weak NPIs and minimizers may appear in clause-initial position under Narrative Fronting (as in 35 and 36) is just one aspect of this larger generalization. In cases like (35) and (36), the fronted NPI remains within the scope of sentential negation just like the indefinites of (45) and the disjuncts of (46), and this is why such examples are fully well-formed.

¹⁷Note that the claim is not that wide-scope indefinites are never found in the fronted position of a Narrative Fronting structure. They are, though rarely. That is, they are found with the same degree of difficulty and at the same (low) level of frequency as is characteristic of indefinites in the base-position of the movement. That is, Narrative Fronting does not expand or change the scopal properties of fronted elements with respect to negation.

4.3 Narrative fronting and ellipsis

If the conclusions of the previous subsection are safe, the path is clear towards resolving the apparent anomaly I opened with: how there can be answers like (2), which consist only of a negative polarity item, in apparent violation of an otherwise valid crosslinguistic generalization. Following Merchant (2004: 691), we can maintain that the possibility of fragment answers consisting of, or containing, NPIs is parasitic on a prior application of Narrative Fronting.¹⁸ A routine application of Narrative Fronting raises the NPI to the left periphery, and the clausal remnant from which it has been raised is, if conditions warrant, elided by a sluicing-like operation that eliminates all but the fronted phrase. The apparently isolated NPIs are well-formed because they are within the scope of negation in a pre-ellipsis representation, and they have the interpretations that they do because of the scope-preserving property of Narrative Fronting. Many languages disallow the equivalents of (30–31) because they lack a movement operation with the particular set of properties that we have demonstrated for Narrative Fronting in Irish (though see Laka 1993 and Giannakidou 2000 for cases of the same general type). In (47b), which involves a minimizer, L’s response will be derived roughly as in (48b), in which I use a greyed-out font to indicate elided material.

- (47) a. J: Ná habair a dhath le n-ár gcairde.
 C.NEG.FIN say.IMPV anything with our friends
 ‘Don’t say anything to our friends.’
 b. L: Smid.
 breath
 ‘Not a word.’
- (48) a. Smid ní dhéarfaidh mé le n-ár gcairde.
 breath C.NEG.FIN say.FUT I with our friends
 ‘I won’t breathe a word to our friends.’
 b. i. ní dhéarfaidh mé smid le n-ár gcairde.
 ii. smid ní dhéarfaidh mé – le n-ár gcairde.
 iii. smid [ní dhéarfaidh mé – le n-ár gcairde]

¹⁸The link between Narrative Fronting and the possibility of fragment NPIs is made independently in D’Antuono (2024).

There is an additional set of observations that shows that the link between Narrative Fronting and legal fragment-types is very tight. There are items in Irish which resemble NPIs in many respects but to which Narrative Fronting may not apply. One of these is a focus-exceptive construction, which is one of the ways of expressing *only*. In these structures, which have much in common with the *ne-que* construction of French, the exceptive particle *ach* attaches to a focused phrase (or to a larger phrase which includes a focused phrase) within the domain of sentential negation:

- (49) a. Ní-or labhair ach seisear.
C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST but six.people
'Only six people spoke.'
- b. Ní ólaim ach tae.
C.NEG.FIN drink.PRES.S1 but tea
'I drink only tea.'
- c. Ní raibh gluaisteán ach aige daoine saibhre an uair sin
C.NEG.FIN be.PAST car but at people rich the time DEMON
'Only rich people had cars at that time.' ABFS 26

Ach-phrases like those in (49), interpreted like 'only', are licensed in some, but not quite all, of the contexts in which NPIs are licensed. They appear, for instance, in the scope of negation or in polar questions:

- (50) a. nó an raibh ann acht rud a samhladh dó
or C.Q was in.it but thing C imagine.PAST.IMPERS to.him
'Or was it only something he imagined?' LCS 110
- b. An raibh ach an t-aon Naomh amháin ina measc go léir?
C.Q was but the one saint one in-their-midst all
'Or was there only one Saint among them all?' AG 113

Despite their kinship with NPIs (discussed in McCloskey 2013) such exceptives are excluded from Narrative Fronting structures:

- (51) *Ach do dheartháir ní raibh ag an chruinniú aréir.
but your brother C.NEG.FIN be.PAST at the meeting last.night
'Only your brother was at the meeting last night.'

They are also correspondingly impossible as fragments, as shown in (52):

- (52) a. Cé a bhí ag an chruinniú aréir?
who c be.PAST at the meeting last.night
'Who was at the meeting last night?'
- b. *Ach do dheartháir.
but your brother
'Only your brother.'

Such close correlations are expected on the account developed here.¹⁹

4.4 English Redux

Before we move on to larger questions, there is a final empirical issue that should be dealt with: this chapter opened by announcing the goal of better understanding a claimed contrast between English and Irish – that Irish does, but English does not, allow fragment NPIs. There is, though, a strand of research that questions the claim for English – or at least suggests that the facts are more nuanced (den Dikken et al. 2000; Valmala 2007; Weir 2014; Weir 2015). At issue is what we should conclude about the example in (53):

- (53) Q: What DIDN'T Owen buy? A: Any wine.

As all investigators have been careful to note, (53) is not accepted by all speakers and is, for many or most, of intermediate acceptability (I know of no quantitative study). The conditions that allow the fragment NPI in (53) seem also to be quite stringent; as noted by den Dikken et al. (2000: fn3, 44–45) and Weir (2014: 167–171), what is required is a negative WH-question with verum focus and a discourse context that includes, implicitly or explicitly, a set of propositions like that in (54):

- (54) Owen bought pizza.
Owen bought bottled water.
Owen bought beer.
Owen bought chips.

The possibility in (53) also seems to be linked to the possibility of specificational pseudo-clefts in English like those in (55), in which the appearance of the NPI within the pivot position is also puzzling on most accounts.

- (55) a. What we didn't make was (we didn't make) any progress.
b. What Owen didn't buy was (he didn't buy) any wine.

¹⁹Speakers often use Narrative Fronting in providing paraphrases for fragment answers.

It is exactly this connection that den Dikken et al. (2000) are centrally concerned with and in pursuing that connection they are brought to the conclusion that (53) is an elided form of (56):

(56) Q: What DIDN'T Owen buy? A: [He didn't buy] any wine.

The connection with the pseudoclefts in (55) is then that the relation between the WH-clause and the pivot in such constructions is similar in essential respects to the question-answer relation in (53) and (56). In both cases, the polarity item is licensed within a full finite clause that is subject to optional elision. Important support for this proposal derives from the generalization, which they establish, that bare NPI pivots are possible in pseudoclefts just in case the full clausal option is also possible (as illustrated in 55).

Weir (2014; 2015) builds on these insights to develop an analysis that is consistent with the idea that fragment answers are in general derived by movement followed by elision of all but the moved element. It also accounts for the marginal character of (53) by assuming that the movement in question takes place in the derivation of phonological forms (and its effects are therefore invisible to semantic conditions such as those essential to the licensing of polarity items) and is a marked and 'last resort' operation – one that is specific to that context and one which applies only to head off the possibility that a focus marked expression might be elided.

These issues are difficult and important, but they clearly do not challenge the empirical claim that was the starting point for the present chapter: that Irish and English differ fundamentally with respect to the well-formedness of NPI fragments. The Irish cases we have been concerned with are in no way marked or recondite; nor are they variably acceptable or restricted to very particular contexts, as is the English possibility in (53). They are simply routine aspects of the grammar of the language: productive and unmarked.

The proposals developed here account for that property of Irish and are also compatible with the framework developed for the English cases by Weir and his predecessors. The difference between the two languages is that the grammar of Irish includes a syntactic operation that is routine and productive, and that renders appeal to marked or 'last resort' operations unnecessary. The grammar of English, by contrast, includes no such operation and in providing a structural description for (53) must rely on the logic of last resort.

4.5 The Syntax of Negation and the Syntax of Narrative Fronting

For the announced purpose of this chapter (resolving the apparent anomaly of NPI fragments), this is arguably as far as we need to go. It has been shown that the syntax of Irish must include a mechanism by which NPIs can be raised to a clause-peripheral position and that in that position raised expressions remain within the semantic scope of sentential negation and NPIs are therefore licensed. That much is close to incontrovertible. In addition, we need to appeal to an ellipsis process that elides the clause from which the NPI has been raised; but the process we must appeal to is of a kind that is familiar, well-studied, and well-attested.

There remain, though, obvious and large questions about how such a system can be integrated within some credible larger theory of Irish clausal syntax. I want to say something about those questions here, but the discussion will of necessity be somewhat unsatisfying because the issues that arise cannot be fully addressed within the scope of a chapter such as this.

Consider first the extended projection of the verb-initial finite clauses of the language. Sentential negation is expressed overtly in these clauses on *c*; every candidate complementizer in the language (interrogative, *wh*, conditional, root, default ...) is paired with a negative counterpart with which it competes in the system of exponence (see McCloskey 2001 for data and discussion).

However, McCloskey (2017) argues that the expression of negation in finite clauses in Irish is, in fact, distributed over two positions linked by an agreement relation: (i) on *c*, the highest element of the extended clausal projection where its morphological exponence appears, and (ii) on a lower polarity head, one which appears in an arguably more expected position below the expression of clausal force and that is the position relevant for the semantics of polarity.

In finite clauses, the two polarity positions are separated by a head that has as its exponents the various preverbal tense markers of the language and that expresses a (limited) combination of tense and modality properties. We will call that element here *TM1*. The finite clause in (57), then, has the schematic structure in Figure 1.

- (57) Ní -or óladar aon nimh sa teach.
 c -PAST drink.PAST.P3 any poison in.the house
 ‘They did not drink any poison in the house.’

The complement of that head is, in turn, projected by a lower tense-modality head, one which expresses a set of tense and modality distinctions that further refine those introduced by *TM1*. This head (*TM2*) is realized morphologically in the

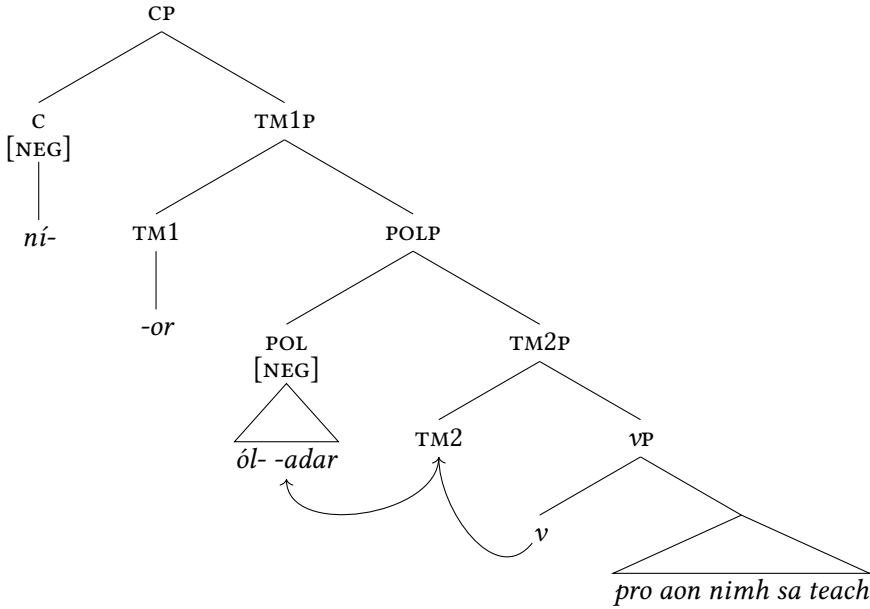


Figure 1: Tree for (57)

post-verbal inflectional suffixes and hosts a raised subject in its specifier, yielding vso order.

In nonfinite clauses, which are characterized by an absence of head-movement, the lower polarity head hosts the overt marker of negation (*gan*), which clearly appears in a position lower than *c*, and which precedes subject-position:

- (58) Ba mhian leat gan mé creidbheáil ins an rud.
 COP.PAST desire with.you NEG.NONFIN me believe.VN in the thing
 ‘You wanted me not to believe in the thing.’ UMI 167

How might Narrative Fronting be integrated into this framework? The point reached earlier is summarized in (59), repeated from (41) above.

- (59) NARRATIVE FRONTING:
 The finite negation head may include a probe that attracts XPs that are alternative-evoking.

We can begin by assuming that there is a feature *ALT* that identifies alternative-evoking expressions to the syntax. This feature, I assume, is part of the lexical specification of NPIs, one of the ways in which the pure numeral use of *aon*,

for instance, is distinguished from its NPI use. Narrative Fronting, then, will be understood as a probe-goal interaction between a negative head and a phrase in its local domain which bears the ALT-feature; in that interaction, the target phrase is raised to the specifier position of the polarity head.

But given the structure in Figure 1, we now have two candidate heads to consider when asking which head hosts the crucial probe: the higher negative *c* or the lower polarity head. Given that in the overt structure, the raised XP appears to the left of the negative complementizer, the answer to that question would seem to be obvious. One might think that the ALT-probe is an optional subpart of the negative complementizer and that Narrative Fronting is, therefore, movement to its specifier position.

Alternatively, it could be that the probe that attracts the alternative-evoking expression into its specifier position is hosted by the lower (negative) polarity head. Following raising of the finite verb to the polarity position, the fronted XP will appear to the left of the inflected verb and niched between the two (linked) expressions of negation. (60) would then have the syntax shown in Figure 2.

- (60) Focal amháin féin ní-or labhair ceachtar acu.
 word one even C.NEG-PAST speak.PAST either at.them
 ‘Not even a single word did either of them speak.’ INIT 164

The first option (raising to the specifier of negative *C*) accounts immediately for the observed order of constituents: the raised XP in Narrative Fronting always precedes the expression of finite negation. But it is problematic in important ways as well. In particular, this analysis defines Narrative Fronting as a movement to the clause-edge, thus risking the incorrect prediction that the operation would have the same locality-profile as the much-studied $\bar{A}$ -movements of the language. It does not, though. As shown in McCloskey (1996), Narrative Fronting is movement to a TP-internal position and is strictly clause-bound.

In addition, the observed word-order in cases like (60) is guaranteed by the proposal developed in McCloskey (1996) that finite complementizers in general in Irish attain their pronounced positions by way of a postsyntactic operation that lowers them, across intervening material if present, to the position of the inflected verb. On this view, *c*-lowering is an exact analog of English τ -lowering (the ‘affix-hopping’ of Chomsky 1957) and is justified by exactly the same kind of argument. In the case of Irish, *c*-lowering is one of a set of post-syntactic operations which jointly create the complex morphological word known in the Irish linguistic tradition as the ‘verbal complex’, whose properties and intricate internal structure have been studied, for example, by Jason Ostrove (2018). In the

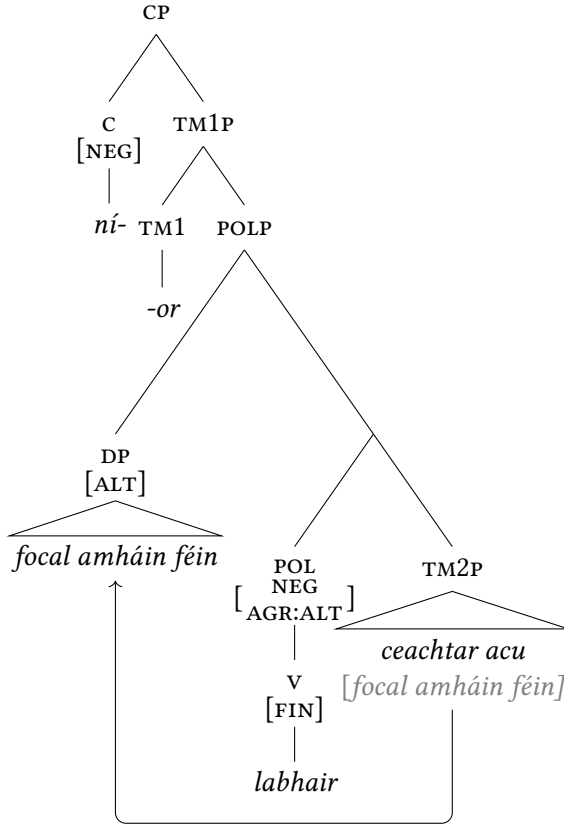


Figure 2: Tree for (60)

case of (60), the effect is to create a complex morphological word of the form in (61) in the position of the polarity head:

(61) { C-NEG-TM1-ROOT-VCE-TM2 }

In the context of the c-lowering proposal, the analysis in Figure 2 becomes natural. On this account, the fronted XP is commanded by an expression of negation at every point in its derivational career and standard (and natural) mechanisms provide an understanding of the fact that Narrative Fronting applies only in negative clauses (an important advance over the account offered in McCloskey 1996), while avoiding the risk of predicting that the operation would have the locality-profile of an $\bar{A}$ -movement.

The proposal of c-lowering has been controversial (see for instance Maki & Ó Baoill 2017, who show that one of the strands of evidence offered in McCloskey

1996 was based on a misinterpretation of the relevant evidence), but I know of no competitor proposal that deals with the range of facts it accounts for. In addition, there is no reason for embarrassment in a contemporary theoretical setting concerning appeal to a post-syntactic (as opposed to syntactic) lowering.

In the context of Figure 2, the ellipsis process appealed to in accounting for the fragment answers of, for instance, (30), (31) or (47b) – one which will eliminate all but the phrase fronted by Narrative Fronting – will emerge as a familiar kind of polarity ellipsis triggered by an ellipsis-licensing feature (Merchant’s E) on the lower polarity head.²⁰ Further, following Benjabi & Pesetsky (2022), I will assume that in this case the E -feature extends to the immediate projection of the polarity head, ensuring elimination from the pronounced string of all but the specifier of the licensing head.

Much hard work clearly remains to be done on all of these questions. But I hope to have shown in this brief discussion that the project of integrating the proposals of this chapter into a credible larger theory of clause structure (in Irish) is far from being a hopeless one.

5 Implications

The proposal outlined here (and anticipated in Merchant’s paper) depends on a central element of the ‘move and delete’ approach articulated by Merchant (2004) for subsentential fragments of propositional type. That approach links the ellipsis possibilities found in a given language with the inventory of movement-types available in that language. That inventory in turn reflects the inventory of probes in the language; so we have yet another case in which variation among languages has its roots in combinatorial properties of elements of the functional vocabulary. In the absence of such an approach, it is not clear how to make the required connection between the possibility of fragment NPIs and the existence and properties of Narrative Fronting.

The analysis also preserves the essence of the generalization that NPIs may not function as fragment answers. The possibility of NPI fragments will emerge in a language only if it has a movement operation that is not scope-enhancing and so does not raise the moved item out of the crucial licensing context. Irish does not show that the initial generalization is wrong, then, but rather suggests a refinement.²¹ This clarification too depends in a fundamental way on the move-and-delete approach to this kind of fragment response.

²⁰For an interesting comparison see especially Gribanova (2017) on polarity ellipses in Russian.

²¹The implication is, obviously, that in diagnosing some constituent as either an NPI or a negative concord item, one should not use the fragment answer diagnostic in a simplistic way. Before

Most important, perhaps, the arguments supporting an ellipsis-based analysis of at least this type of fragment response are quite powerful. Few expression-types are as subtly dependent on context as are NPIs; their interpretation and their well-formedness depend on very particular properties of the compositional settings in which they appear. And even those who have pushed hardest to construct a fundamentally semantic or pragmatic understanding of how NPIs are licensed and interpreted recognize that the definition of that compositional setting has a syntactic component (see, for example Ladusaw 1979: 206–207). Gajewski (2005), Homer (2011), and Homer (2021), in particular, have developed persuasive arguments that even the fundamental semantic constraint – that NPIs must appear in (Strawson) downward-entailing environments – must be stated in terms both syntactic and semantic, as in (62):

- (62) An NPI α is licensed in sentence S only if there is a (syntactic) constituent A of S containing α such that A is downward-entailing with respect to the position of α . (Homer 2021: 5)

That is, syntactic constituents (rather than ‘operators’) are downward or upward entailing (in virtue, of course, of their interpretive properties). In turn, what this means is that the minimizer fragment *smid* in the exchange in (47b) above, if it is to be appropriately interpreted and licensed, must appear within a syntactic constituent whose semantic properties are such that it is (Strawson) downward entailing with respect to the position of *smid*. This is guaranteed in a straightforward way by the ellipsis analysis, because its principal commitment is exactly that the minimizer in (47b) is contained within an interpreted syntactic structure of the required kind – though one that happens not to be pronounced. It is difficult to imagine how the required compositional scaffolding (semantic and syntactic) might be supplied in an approach to fragments that eschewed such silent structure.

But if appeal to ellipsis is correct for this material, there are also implications for what the theory of ellipsis must then look like. Consider again some examples of NPI fragment responses:

- (63) a. “Beidh na girseachaí leat.” “Ó go bráthach!”
 be.FUT the girls with.you ever
 “The girls will be with you.” “Oh, never!”ATFS 505

concluding that an element is a negative concord item on the basis of the test, one needs to ask if the language has an independently available mechanism that could displace an NPI out of a potential ellipsis-site, yielding a pattern like the one discussed here for Irish.

- b. “Cá mhéad a bhéas ar sin?” “Pingin ar bith,” arsa bean a’
 what amount c be.PRES on that penny any said woman the
 tsiopa.
 shop.GEN
 “How much will that be?” “Not a penny,” said the shop-woman.’ BRD
 81
- c. Cé a d’ inis duitse go bhfuil tú ag déanamh mar
 who C.WH PAST- tell.PAST to.you c be.PRES you PROG do.VN as
 is ceart? Aon duine.
 is right one person
 ‘Who told you that you were doing the right thing?’ ‘Nobody.’ ISNB
 139
- d. “Beidh dornán maith mónadh de dhíobháil ortha le teinte a
 be.FUT quantity good peat.GEN of need on.them to fires VCE
 choinneáil ann.” “Fód ar bith.”
 keep.VN in.it sod any
 “They’ll need a lot of turf (peat) to keep the fires going in it.” “Not a
 sod.” ST 206

For each example in (63), there is a very natural paraphrase in terms of Narrative Fronting:

- (64) a. Go bráthach [ní bheidh na girseachaí liom].
 ‘Never will the girls be with me.’
 b. Pingin ar bith [ní bheidh ar sin].
 ‘That won’t cost a penny.’
 c. Aon duine [níor inis domh go raibh mé ag déanamh mar is ceart].
 ‘Not one person told me that I was doing the right thing.’
 d. Fód ar bith [ní bheidh de dhiobháil orthu].
 ‘Not one sod will they need.’

In each case, the elided clause must include sentential negation to license the stranded polarity item and to guarantee the right interpretation. However, no matching negation appears in the apparent antecedent. Such examples are very frequent (see also 2, all four in 30, and two in 31 above) and they add to the steady accumulation of evidence in recent years that elided clauses are not required to match their antecedents in polarity (Yoshida 2010; Toosarvandani 2013; Kroll & Rudin 2018; Rudin 2019; Kroll 2019; Anand et al. 2021; Ranero 2021). Further, these

examples are of a particular type: negation appears in the elided clause but not in its antecedent. This is worth noting because in work on sluicing in English it has been observed (Anand et al. 2021) that this pattern is rarer than its inverse (negation in the antecedent, no negation in the ellipsis-site).

The issues around antecedence do not end here though. In question-response pairs, it is usually easy to identify an appropriate overt antecedent. However, NPI fragments also occur in contexts in which there is no such antecedent:

- (65) a. Bhain sé triail as an uimhir fóin. Freagra ar bith.
 took.PAST he try out.of the number phone.GEN answer any
 ‘He tried the phone number. No answer.’ TAIR 114
- b. Chuaigh mé amach a dh’éisteacht le ceol na n-éan.
 go.PAST I out to-listen with music the.GEN birds.GEN
 Fuaim dá laghad.
 sound of.the least
 ‘I went out to listen to the singing of the birds. Not a sound.’ RNG
 20-10-18
- c. Níl aon uaigh ann, a Dheaid. Chuartaigh muid an áit
 is.not one grave in.it VOC-PTC Dad search.PAST we the place
 ó bhun go barr. Tada.
 from bottom to top anything
 ‘There’s no grave, Dad. We searched the place from top to bottom.
 Nothing.’ A 98

These are all attested examples. (65a) was also checked with six native speaker consultants, all of whom accepted it without hesitation as natural, well-formed, and clear. The crucial property of such cases is that, although the evidence for ellipsis is as clear and as strong as for the other instances of NPI fragments, there is no overt antecedent in the discourse context. However, there is in each case a strongly salient but implicit question (a *QUD* in the sense of Roberts 2012) – *Would he get an answer? What would he hear? What did they find?* – in the local discourse context.

Given how strong the evidence for ellipsis is in such fragment answer cases, it seems we must conclude (with Merchant 2004: Section 5) that, for certain kinds of ellipsis at least, antecedents with the necessary kind of syntactic and semantic properties may be found in discourse representations rather than in any overt linguistic signal. This conclusion runs against the grain of certain trends in the study of ellipsis, some of which tend to assume that if there is no overt

antecedent there can be no “syntax in the silence” (to use Merchant’s phrase). But the conclusion is, in a certain sense, profoundly unsurprising. The initiators of one of the most sophisticated and influential frameworks for the study of discourse dynamics Farkas & Bruce (2010) take the following position:

We follow the literature ... in having a discourse component that records the questions under discussion ... and assume that the items on it are syntactic objects paired with their denotations. (Farkas & Bruce 2010: 86)

The reason that they adopt this position is exactly that “the grammar of cross-turn conversation and ellipsis has to have access to the grammatical form (and not just the content) of immediately previous utterances” (Farkas & Bruce 2010: 86).

6 Conclusion

Working on ellipsis is very difficult and can feel frustrating. The problems are unimaginably more challenging than they seemed to be fifty years ago and it is easy to yield sometimes to the feeling that little theoretical progress has been made in the interim, even though there are uncountably many more observations available to us now that might shape theory-development.

Part of the difficulty is that it remains unclear for what phenomena the general theory of ellipsis is supposed to be responsible. The case of subsentential fragments is a classic one of that type; the exchange between Stainton (2006) and Merchant (2010) in particular makes that very clear. I take the present chapter to be a modest contribution to that difficult and important area.

However, working on ellipsis also often brings useful spin-offs. In the present case, it has led to a more complete survey of the landscape of polarity-sensitive items in Irish than has been available before. It has also led to a better understanding of Narrative Fronting – one of the more intriguing components of the syntax-pragmatics interface in Irish – than has been available before.

And finally the chapter has also, I hope, provided a clearer view of what the extended projection of finite clauses in Irish looks like. Research on extended projections and research on ellipsis are deeply entangled because the correct theory of the extended projections for a given language must provide a basis for understanding what the inventory of ellipsis processes in that language are.

Acknowledgements

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Appendix A The licensing environments

This appendix presents data concerning the range of licensing environments in which the polarity-sensitive expressions discussed in Section 2 may appear.

A.1 In questions

All of the PSEs of Section 2 appear in polar questions, root and embedded:

(66) EMBEDDED POLAR QUESTIONS:

- a. féachaint an samhlódh faic dom
to-see-if c.Q imagine.IMPERS anything/nothing to.me
‘to see if anything would spring to mind for me’ AGMTS 3
- b. go bhfeicfeadh muid an raibh tada beo tar éis na hóiche
c see.COND we c.Q be.PAST anything alive after the night
‘so that we could see if anything was alive after the night’ IMSBRM 55

(67) ROOT POLAR QUESTIONS:

- a. An féidir liom tada a fháil duit?
c.Q possible with.me anything get.NFIN for.you
‘Can I get anything for you?’ DEAD 149

- b. Agus a-r ghnóthaigh sí aon rás eile i mbliana?
and C.Q.-PAST win.PAST she one race other this-year
'And did she win any other race this year?' RNG 26-08-19

The issue of under what conditions NPIs are licensed in *WH*-questions has been important in debates about the nature of NPI-licensing (Giannakidou 1999, 2011, Guerzoni & Sharvit 2007, Mayr 2013). The PSEs we care about here appear in such questions, root and embedded:

- (68) WH-QUESTIONS:
- a. Cé eile a bhfuil fhios aige tada faoi seo?
who other c be.PRES knowledge at.him anything about this
'Who else knows anything about this?' CAB 89
- b. Goidé mar a thiofadh liom aon fhear a phósadh?
how c come.COND with.me any man VCE marry.VN
'How could I marry any man?' AM 162
- c. Cén chaoi a mbeadh fhios acu tada?
what way c be.COND knowledge at.them anything
'How would they know anything?' SMC 304
- d. Cé a chreidfeadh go raibh sé ariamh bródúil?
who c believe.COND c be.PAST he ever proud
'Who would believe that he was ever proud?' ATFS 51

Many of these cases involve rhetorical questions, e.g. (68b–d). Others are information-seeking questions which require exhaustive answers, as in (68a), a pattern which is consistent in particular with the work of Guerzoni & Sharvit (2007) and Mayr (2013). Whether or not this pattern holds consistently is something which remains to be investigated.

A.2 In conditional clauses

The PSEs of Section 2 may also appear, with their characteristic existential interpretation, in conditional clauses, both realis (69a) and irrealis (69b,c):

- (69) a. Má chaitheann tú choíchin tada a rá, abair
if must.PRES you ever anything say.NFIN say.IMPV
go cuí é.
appropriately it
'If you ever have to say anything, say it appropriately.'

- b. Dá mbeadh baint ar bith leis na gnóithe agam.
if be.COND connection any with the business at.me
'if I had any say in the matter' CLM 38
- c. dá dtarlaíodh tada dá hathair
if happen.COND anything to.her father
'if anything should happen to her father' AA 177

A.3 In excessive-degree clauses

Phrases in construction with the degree-word *ró-* ('too') also freely host PSEs:

- (70) a. Tá sé ró- mhall anois tada a dhéanamh.
be.PRES it too late now anything VCE do.VN
'It's too late to do anything now.' AA 158
- b. bhí sé ró- the chun éinne bheith ag spaisteoireacht
be.PAST it too hot for anyone be.NFIN PROG stroll.VN
'It was too hot for anyone to be out walking.' DPB 102
- c. duí gainmhe a bhí ró- aimhréidh d' aon ghalfchúrsa
dune sand.GEN C be.PAST too uneven for any golf-course
'a sand-dune that was too uneven for any golf-course' LGL 170

A.4 In equative, comparative and superlative clauses

(71) EQUATIVE CLAUSES:

- a. Bhí cuma air comh folláin agus bhí ariamh
be.PAST appearance on.him as healthy and be.PAST ever
air,
on.him
'He looks as healthy as he ever did.' ATFS 565
- b. culaith éadaigh chomh deas agus a chuir aon fhear riamh
suit clothes.GEN as nice as C.WH put.PAST any man ever
ar a dhroim
on his back
'as nice a suit of clothes as any man ever put on his back' EMPP 163

(72) COMPARATIVE CLAUSES:

- a. Tá níos mó chéill i gcuid cainte Dhomhnaill ná
 be.PRES more sense.GEN in share talk.GEN than
 aidmhigheas aon duine.
 admit.PRES.WH any person
 ‘There’s more sense in Domhnall’s talk than anyone admits.’ MO 135
- b. Bhí fhios aige-sean níos fearr ná bhí
 be.PAST knowledge at.him-CONTR more better than be.PAST
 fhios ag duine ar bith. ...
 knowledge at person any
 ‘He knew better than anyone knew that ...’ AM 415
- c. Is fusa éinne a smachtú ná do chuid
 COP.PRES easy.COMPAR anyone VCE discipline.VN than your portion
 féin.
 REFL.LOG
 ‘It’s easier to discipline anyone than your own (children).’ LGL 122

(73) SUPERLATIVE CLAUSES:

- a. an obair thógála ba deacra dár déanadh
 the work building.GEN COP.PRES difficult.COMPAR C do.PAST.IMPERS
 go hiomlán as Gaeilge ariamh
 entirely out.of Irish ever
 ‘the most difficult building-work that was ever done entirely through
 Irish’ CCT 199
- b. an mheancóg a ba mhó a rinne mé
 the mistake C.WH COP.PAST big.COMPAR C.WH make.PAST I
 ariamh
 ever
 ‘the biggest mistake that I ever made’ ATFS 127

See Hoeksema (1983), von Fintel (1999), Gajewski (2010), Herdan & Sharvit (2006), Bumford & Sharvit (2022), and Howard (2014).

I will include in this group relative clauses attached to head nouns modified by the ordinal *céad* (‘first’), though the status of such phrases as superlatives remains controversial. PSEs are licensed here:

- (74) a. Siod é an chéad am a labhair mé air le aon duine
 that it the first time C speak.PAST I on.it with any person
 ‘That was the first time that I spoke about it with anyone.’ SMC 287

- b. an chéad ál a bhí ariamh aici
 the first litter C be.PAST ever at.her
 ‘the first litter she ever had’ CA 26

A.5 In certain temporal clauses

As in many other languages, PSEs in Irish appear within certain temporal clauses, notably those introduced by ‘before’ or ‘when’, but not those introduced by ‘after’ (Linebarger 1987; Condoravdi 2010; Krifka 2010).

- (75) a. sul a raibh am ag an sáirsint aon cheo a rá leis
 before C be.PAST time at the sergeant one mist VCE say.VN with.him
 ‘before the sergeant had time to say the slightest thing to him’ LSC 202
- b. sul má bheidh a fhios aige tada
 before C be.FUT knowledge at.him anything
 ‘before he knows anything’ CF 129
- c. sul má lonnaigh aon duine ariamh ann
 before C settle.PAST any person ever there
 ‘before anyone ever settled there’ MABAT 74
- (76) a. Bhí siad go han-mhaith dó nuair a bhí a dhath
 be.PAST they PTC very-good to.him when C be.PAST anything
 acu.
 at.them
 ‘They were very good to him when they had anything.’ GOG 266
- b. nuair a theastaíodh dada uaithi bhuaileadh sí
 when C need.PAST.HABIT anything from.her hit.PAST.HABIT she
 cnag ar an urlár
 knock on the floor
 ‘When she needed anything, she would bang on the floor.’ CG 20
- c. Ní tostach dóibh nuair a thagas aon bhac in a
 COP.NEG silent to.them when C come.PRES any obstacle in their
 mbealach.
 way
 ‘They are not silent when any obstacle gets in their way.’ CG 34

An interesting subclass of such predicates are those which express reluctance on the part of an experiencer. These are among Karttunen's (1971) negative implicatives; "they seem to incorporate negation" (Karttunen 1971: 352) and license the inference that in the preference-worlds of their experiencers the eventuality described in their complement is not instantiated.²² NPIs in English are licensed within the complements of such predicates, but not in the experiencer argument-position. In Irish they are, in addition, licensed in the experiencer argument-position. I emphasize the contrast between the two languages in this respect by offering for the examples in (80) literal English translations, which are ill-formed but, interestingly, understandable.²³

- (80) a. Bhí drogall ar aon imreoir suí leis ag clár
 be.PAST reluctance on any player sit.NFIN with.him at board
 na himeartha.
 the.GEN playing.GEN
 'Any player was reluctant to sit with him at the gaming-table.'
 SJCCF 337
- b. Bhí leisce ar aon duine tada a rá.
 be.PAST reluctance on any person anything VCE say.VN
 'Anyone was reluctant to say anything.'
 LGN 96

Similarly, the predicate *cuma* ('matterless, insignificant') allows NPIs in its two argument-positions:

- (81) a. Ba chuma liom faoi thada.
 COP.PAST matterless with.me about anything
 'I didn't care about anything.'
 RNG 31-01-20
- b. Is cuma le ceachtar agaibh fá'n duine eile.
 COP.PRES matterless with either of.you about.the person other
 'Neither of you cares about the other.'
 ATFS 425
 (*lit.* 'Either of you doesn't care about the other.')

The English facts here may be complicated by a language-particular oddity – a requirement that the licensing element precede the licensed NPI (Ladusaw 1979:

²²For a sophisticated and relevant discussion, see von Stechow (1999: 115–121).

²³One might avoid this puzzle by taking the examples in (79), (80) and (81) to involve "free choice" readings. But this move is unlikely to be tenable given that the licensing conditions for such readings are not satisfied in such cases. In addition, the possibilities shown in (79–81) hold only for predicates whose meaning in some sense includes a negative component (Klima 1964, Karttunen 1971, Kadmon & Landman 1993, von Stechow 1999).

206–207). It is also possible that the relevant arguments in Irish are internal and therefore within the scope of the (negative component of the) licensing predicate.

A.7 In the restrictive clause of a universal quantification structure

The final licensing environment to be documented is once again a familiar one: the restrictive clause of a universal quantification structure.

The most frequent case of this type involves NPIs which have “free choice” or quasi-universal readings. On this possibility (in English) see Horn (2000: 163). A relative clause attached to such an element acts as the restrictor for the universal quantification that it expresses and PSEs appear freely.

- (82) a. *éinne go bhfuil aon chiall aige*
 anyone C be.PRES any sense at.him
 ‘anyone who has any sense’ G 11
- b. *fear ar bith a bhfuil fhios aige tada*
 man any C be.PRES knowledge at.him anything
 ‘any man who knows anything’ CNF 25
- c. *am ar bith a mbeadh a dhath le rádh aige liom*
 time any C be.COND anything to say.VN at.him with.me
 ‘any time he had anything to say to me’ LCS 201

Unconditional clauses, which in Irish are marked by means of a distinctive WH-determiner (*pé*, or *cibé*), similarly host PSEs:

- (83) *pé pingin a bhí riamh acu*
 whatever penny C be.PAST ever at.them
 ‘whatever pennies they ever had’ AI 199

It is hardly a surprise, then, that PSEs are also licensed within relative clauses that restrict nominals headed by explicit universal quantifiers:

- (84) a. *timpeall ar chuile áit a gceapfaidís a mbeadh aon deis*
 around on every place C think.COND.P3 C be.COND any opportunity
 ag an ngail a bheith ag éalú
 at the steam be.NFIN PROG escape.VN
 ‘around every place that they’d think there was any opportunity for the steam to escape’
- b. *Gach neach a thug cath éagórach riamh d’ Fhionn*
 every being C give.PAST battle unjust ever to
 ‘every being who ever joined battle unjustly with Fionn’ SNAF 226

Appendix B Sources of examples

- A: *Aileach*, Jackie Mac Donncha, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2010
- AA: *Athaoibhneas*, Pádhraic Óg Ó Conaire, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1959
- AAG: *As an nGéibheann*, Máirtín Ó Cadhain, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1973
- ABFS: *An Baile i bhFad Siar*, Domhnall Mac an tSíthigh, Coiscéim, 2000
- ABHM: *Ábhar Machnaimh*, An tAthair Donncha Ó Corcora, Foilseacháin Náisiúnta Teoranta, 1985
- ACED: *An Chuid Eile Díom Féin – Aistí le Máirtín Ó Direáin*, ed. Siobhra Aiken, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2018
- AE: *An Eochair*, Máirtín Ó Cadhain, Dalkey Archive Press, 2015
- AFAP: *An Fear a Phléasc*, Mícheál Ó Conghaile, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 1997
- AG: *An Gabhar Sa Teampall*, Mícheál Ua Ciarmhaic, Coiscéim, 1986
- AGFC: *An Grá Faoi Cheilt*, Pádraig Ó Cíobháin, Coiscéim, 1992
- AGMTS: *Ar Gach Maoilinn Tá Síocháin*, Pádraig Ó Cíobháin, Coiscéim, 1991
- AG: *An Gabhar Sa Teampall*, Mícheál Ua Ciarmhaic, Coiscéim, 1986
- AI: *Allagar na hInise*, Tomás Ó Criomhthain, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1977
- AL: *Abair Leat*, Joe Daly, ed. Pádraig Tyers, An Sagart, 1999
- AM: *An Mhiorbhailt*, C.B Kelland, trans. Niall Mac Suibhne, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, 1936
- AN: *Athnuachan*, Máirtín Ó Cadhain, Coiscéim, 1995
- ANNF: *Ar Nós na bhFáinleog*, Siobhán Ní Shúilleabháin, Coiscéim, 2004
- APB: *An Prionsa Beag*, Antoine de Saint-Exupéry, trans. Eoghan Mac Giolla Bhríde, Éabhlóid, 2015
- ATFS: *Ag Teacht Fríd an tSeagal*, Helen Mathers, trans. Seosamh Mac Grianna, An Gúm, 1932
- ATIM: *An tIolrach Mór, Díoghluim Gearr-Sgéal*, Pádhraic Ó Domhnalláin, Brún agus Ó Nualláin, 1941
- ATT: *An tSraith Tógtha*, Máirtín Ó Cadhain, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1977
- BM: *Bullaí Mhártain*, Síle Ní Chéileachair agus Donncha Ó Céilleachair, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1969
- BRD: *Bean Ruadh de Dhálach*, Séamus Ó Grianna, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, 1966
- BTFS: *An Blascaod Trí Fhuinneog na Scoile*, Nóra Ní Shéaghdha, ed. Pádraig Ó hÉalaí, An Sagart, 2015
- C: *Clochmhóin*, Joe Steve Ó Neachtain, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 1998
- CA: *Cnuasacht Airneáin*, Colm Ó Ceallaigh, Coiscéim, 2006
- CAA: *Conamara agus Árainn 1880–1890: Gnéithe den Stair Shóisialta*, Mícheál Ó Conghaile, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 1988

- CAB: *Carraig an Bháis*, Colm Ó Ceallaigh, Coiscéim, 2007
- CC: *Cruithneacht agus Ceannabháin*, Tomás Bairéad, Comhlucht Oideachais na hÉireann, 1940
- CCT: *Camchuairt Chonamara Theas*, Tim Robinson, trans. Liam Mac Con Iomaire, Coiscéim, 2002
- CDC: *Castar na Daoine ar a Chéile, Scríbhinní Mháire 1*, Séamus Ó Grianna, ed. Nollaig Mac Congail, Coiscéim, 2002
- CF: *Cois Fharraige Le Mo Linnse*, Seán Ó Conghaile, Clódhanna Teoranta, 1974
- CFC: *Céad Fáilte go Cléire*, ed. Marion Gunn, An Clóchomhar Tta, 1990
- CG: *Ceol na nGiolcach*, Padhraic Óg Ó Conaire, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1968
- CGC: *Caillte i gConamara, Scéalta Aniar*, ed. Brian Ó Conchubhair, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2014
- CHD: *Chicago Driver*, Maidhc Dainín Ó Sé, Coiscéim, 1992
- CLM: *Cúl le Muir agus Scéalta Eile*, Séamus Ó Grianna, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1961
- CNF: *Clann na Feannóige*, Colm Ó Ceallaigh, Coiscéim, 2004
- COC: *Cora Cinniúna*, Séamus Ó Grianna, ed. Niall Ó Domhnaill, An Gúm, 1993
- CTP: *Cuimhne an tSeanpháiste*, Mícheál Breatnach, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1966
- D: *An Draoidín*, Séamus Ó Grianna, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, 1959
- DEAD: *Déirc an Díomhaointis*, Pádhraic Óg Ó Conaire, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1972
- DGD: *Deoir Ghoirt an Deoraí*, Colm Ó Ceallaigh, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 1993
- DPB: *Dualgas Pheadair Bhig*, trans. Séamus Ó Maolchathaigh, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1953
- DR: *Dracula*, Bram Stoker, trans. Seán Ó Cuirrín, An Gúm, 1933/1997
- EMPP: *Eachtraí Mara Phaidí Pheadair as Toraigh*, Séamus Mac a' Bhaird, ed. Aingeal Nic a' Bhaird, Caoimhín Mac a' Bhaird, Nollaig Mac Congail, Arlen House, 2019
- FB: *Feamain Bhealtaine*, Máirtín Ó Direáin, An Clóchomhar Tta., 1961
- FF: *Fonn na Fola*, Beairtle Ó Conaire, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2005
- G: *Greenhorn*, Maidhc Dainín Ó Sé, Coiscéim, 1997
- GDDR: *Go dTaga do Ríocht, Boicíní Bhóthar Kilburn, Cripil Inis Meáin*, Mícheál Ó Conghaile, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2009
- GFH: *An Ghlan-fhírinne*, Cóil Learaí Ó Finneadha, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2014
- GOG: *Glórtha ón Ghorta: Béaloideas na Gaeilge agus an Gorta Mór*, Cathal Póirtéir, Coiscéim, 1996
- GSA: *An Giorria San Aer*, Ger Ó Cíobháin, Coiscéim, 1992
- IAE: *In Aimsir Emmet*, James Murphy trans. Colm Ó Gaora, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, Dublin, 1937

- IMSBM: *Idir Mná: Scríbhneoirí Ban Ros Muc*, ed. Máire Holmes, Pléaráca Chonamara, 1995
- INIT: *Idir Neamh is Talamh*, Joe Steve Ó Neachtain, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2014
- ISNB: *Iad Seo Nach Bhfaca*, Beairtle Ó Conaire, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2010
- LAN: *Leoithne Aniar*, ed. Pádraig Tyers, Cló Dhuibhne, Baile an Fhéirtéaraigh, 1982
- LCS: *Le Clap-Sholus*, Séamas Ó Grianna, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1967
- LGL: *Le Gealaigh*, Pádraig Ó Cíobháin, Coiscéim, 1991
- LGN: *Le Gean agus scéalta eile*, Mike P. Ó Conaola, Sián, 2020
- LL: *Lámh Láidir*, Joe Steve Ó Neachtain, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 2005
- LOFRS: *Liam Ó Flaithearta - Rogha Scéalta*, trans. Mícheál Ó Conghaile, Cló Iar-Chonnacht, 2020
- LSC: *Lig Sinn i gCathú*, Breandán Ó hEithir, Sáirséal agus Dill, 1976
- MABAT: *Mar a Bhí Ar dTús: Cuimhne Seanghasúir*, Joe Steve Ó Neachtain, Cló Iarr-Chonnacht, 2018
- MO: *Muintir An Oileáin*, Peadar O'Donnell, trans. Seosamh Mac Grianna, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, 1952
- NLAB: *Na Laetha a Bhí*, Eoghan Ó Domhnaill, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1968
- OMGS: *Ó Mhuir go Sliabh*, Séamus Ó Grianna, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1961
- OOGC: *Ó Oileán go Cuilleán*, Muiris Ó Súilleabháin, ed. Nuala Uí Aimhirgín, Coiscéim, 2000
- OTA: *Ón tSeanam Anall, Scéalta Mhicí Bháin Uí Bheirn*, ed. Mícheál Mac Giolla Easbuic, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 2008
- PAA: *Peacai Ár nAthaireacha*, Mícheál Ó Súilleabháin, Coiscéim, 1992
- PI: *Punt Isló*, Maidhc Dainín Ó Sé, Coiscéim, 2013
- PNG: *Pobal na Gaeltachta*, ed. Gearóid Ó Tuathaigh, Liam Lillis Ó Laoire, Seán Ua Súilleabháin, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 2000
- RNG: *Raidió na Gaeltachta* (numerical index refers to date of broadcast)
- SIF: *Seanchas Iascaireachta agus Farraige*, Seán Ó hEochaidh, *Béalóideas* 33, 1965
- SJCCF: *Seanchas Jimmí Chearra Chois Fharraige*, ed. Pádraic Ó Cearra, Coiscéim, 2010
- SJSJ: *Seachrán Jeaic Sheáin Johnny*, Mícheál Ó Conghaile, Cló Iarr-Chonnacht, 2002
- SK: *Sáile Chaomhánach*, C.J. Kickham, trans. Máirtín Ó Cadhain, An Gúm, 1932/1986
- SMC: *Stairsheanchas Mhicil Chonraí – Ón Máimín go Ráth Chairn*, ed. Conchúr Ó Giollagáin, Cló Iar-Chonnachta, 1999
- SNAF: *Seanchas na Féinne*, Niall Ó Dónaill, An Gúm, 1943/1996

- SRNF: *Seanchas Rann na Feirste*, Maelsheachlainn Mac Cionaoith, 2006
- SSOTC: *Síscéalta ó Thír Chonaill*, ed. Seán Ó Heochaidh, Máire Ní Néill and Séamas Ó Catháin, Comhairle Bhéaloideas Éireann, 1977
- ST: *An Sean-Teach*, Séamas Ó Grianna, Oifig an tSoláthair, 1968
- TAIR: *Tairngreacht*, Proinsias Mac a' Bhaird, Leabhair Comhar, 2018
- TII: *Tone Inné agus Inniu*, Máirtín Ó Cadhain, Coiscéim, 1992
- TMGB: *Thiar sa Mhainistir atá an Ghaolainn Bhreá*, Brighid Ní Mhóráin, An Sagart, 1997
- TUAIR: *Tuairisc*: online newspaper: <https://tuairisc.ie> (numerical index refers to date of publication)
- UMI: *Uaill-Mhian Iúdaigh*, Roy Bridges, trans. Tadhg Ó Rabhartaigh, Oifig Díolta Foillseacháin Rialtais, 1936

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